DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Roots and Branches: Where Does Israel Begin?

Derech Hashem 2:4:1-3

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 4, paragraphs 1-3 (to the words "omnam" in paragraph 3) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 17 June 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A new chapter: Israel and the nations

After finishing Chapter 3 (the many reasons for what happens to people, which combine into one package under Hashem's control, and the distinction between events that are ends in themselves and those that are means to something else), the Rabbi opened Chapter 4: the difference between Israel and the nations of the world.

The Ramhal prefaces it by calling this one of the deepest matters in Hashem's guidance of the world. On a superficial level, Jews and non-Jews appear completely the same. From the Torah's perspective there is a great difference between them, so much so that he uses the strong, sharp language of different species.

The Rabbi stressed that "we have to be careful how we talk" and what this means. It does not mean that anyone is an animal, and it does not, in itself, mean that one is more important than the other; that question will be discussed. He compared it to the cat family: to someone who is not an expert, a tiger and a leopard look almost the same, but they are different kinds. So too, people may look all the same while being different in kind.

The chapter will explain in what ways we are similar to the nations and in what ways not, and will address questions such as: Who was the first Jew? What does it mean to be a Jew? Why do non-Jews have fewer misvot? How can a non-Jew convert?

Paragraph 2: humanity before and after the sin

To answer, the Ramhal goes back to the very beginning, as he explained in Part 1, Chapter 3. Before his sin, Adam HaRishon was on a far higher level than humanity is now. Had he not sinned, he would have been raised from level to level, and he would have had children in that elevated state, a precise number, as many as Hashem saw fit to receive His goodness, and all would have enjoyed it.

Even in that ideal state, the Ramhal says, not everyone would have been identical. There would have been roots and branches, like trees and their branches, or a family tree with its head and its descendants. The Rabbi clarified that this is not about different spiritual levels, but about structure: certain individuals as roots, and others branching from them. A participant asked

whether this implies that Hashem intended a limited number of people. The Rabbi said yes, a certain number, though no one knows how many; "there may have been billions."

But through his sin Adam fell from his level, darkness became mixed into him, and humanity as a whole went down to a far lower level, no longer fitting for what had been destined. The key line: "and in this state he bore offspring in the world, all on this lower level." This is clear from the Torah itself. Chapter 3 of Bereshit is the sin; only in Chapter 4 does Adam have children.

Not pushed away for ever

Even so, humanity was not pushed away completely. In practice people are born on the lower level, but with the potential to return to the original state. A participant connected this to teshuvah, which Hazal list among the things created before the world.

Hashem gave the generations before the Torah, roughly the first twenty generations, the ability to strengthen themselves and raise themselves back to the higher level. The Rabbi reminded the group that we read Bereshit and Noah in two weeks after Simhat Torah and forget that they span about seventeen hundred years.

But this opportunity had a fixed time limit, set by Hashem's wisdom. The Rabbi compared it to our own lives. We have our 120 years to reach perfection and join the gathering of the perfect; anything that demands effort has a cut-off point.

A participant asked how individuals could rise alone, if all humanity is one interconnected whole. The Rabbi answered with an orchard. Collectively we are one unit, but within it there are branches, and each can grow bigger than others. A neglected orchard can still have one beautiful tree in blossom. Another participant asked whether the time limit was both generational and individual; the Rabbi said it was certainly generational, as well as each person's own lifetime. A third noted that in those early parashiyot, alongside Kayin and the tower of Bavel, there were also righteous people such as Hanokh, Metushelah and Shem: "that's the pull and push."

Paragraph 3: first the roots, then the branches

The ability to return was ordered by roots and branches. Hashem first gave a period for the roots. Whoever repaired himself and prepared himself fittingly in that time would become "a good and precious root," ready for a high level, restored to the good state of Adam. Then all his branches, his descendants, would come out with the same refinement as their root. A participant suggested Kayin and Hevel as an illustration; the Rabbi said the theory is right, though the details will turn out differently.

How long was the time for the roots? Until the generation of the dispersion, the tower of Bavel (dor haflagah). By then Noah was long since born, and so was Avraham. Although Avraham comes to light only in Lekh Lekha, the verses make clear he was born in Parashat Noah and was already alive at the time of the dispersion.

The Rabbi remarked that he has always been surprised the Ramhal does not mention Noah here. A participant suggested that Noah's descendants did not come out straight, so he

evidently did not meet the qualification. The Rabbi agreed: neither did Hanokh or Metushelah, righteous as they were, and they even taught others.

The end of the time of roots

After the flood and the tower, Hashem in His wisdom declared an end to the time of roots. He looked at all of humanity to see who had brought himself back to the state of Adam, and set each person as a root according to his level; his descendants would follow accordingly.

Then comes the part the Rabbi called "a bit sad and depressing." Despite the chance, Hashem's judgement found that everyone was still at the level of Adam after the sin, and their descendants would be no higher. Avraham alone was chosen through his deeds, elevated, and established as a tree of greatness and loftiness, to bear offspring at that level. The Rabbi noted that Avraham recognised Hashem young, but it was at forty-eight, by this account, that he was properly chosen.

So far, the Rabbi concluded, we have not yet spoken about the Jews as a nation, only about the roots. A participant asked: if Avraham's branches are all meant to be perfect, why do we know they were not? "Let's see what happens. To be continued next week."

Summary

- The Ramhal opens Chapter 4 by calling the difference between Israel and the nations one of the deepest matters, using the strong language of different species; the Rabbi urged care with what this means.
- Before the sin, humanity was to be ordered as roots and branches on a high level; after it, Adam's children were born on a lower level.
- Hashem gave humanity a limited time to climb back, first for roots, whose descendants would follow them.
- That time ended with the dispersion after the tower of Bavel.
- Of all humanity, only Avraham had raised himself to become a root of the higher level.

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